



Getting your business found in AI search

Travellers are increasingly asking AI assistants where to go, what to do and where to stay, and acting on the answer. This guide explains how AI search works, why some businesses get recommended and others do not, and exactly what to do about it. It is written for the operators, attractions and accommodation that make up a destination.

PREPARED FOR [DESTINATION] INDUSTRY PARTNERS · WITH THE DIGITAL TOURISM THINK TANK

Generative Engine Optimisation, or GEO, is the practice of structuring your content and your wider presence so AI assistants can understand, trust and recommend your business. This guide takes you from what is changing, through how the systems actually work, to a plan you can start this month. Read it in full, or jump to the checklists and the action plan.

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01 Why this matters now

56%

of travellers used AI for at least one trip in the past year, more than double 2024.

Phocuswright, 2026

78%

of people who use AI to plan have booked based mainly on an AI recommendation.

TakeUp, 2026

fastest

behavioural shift the travel industry has seen in a decade.

Phocuswright, 2026

Search is changing shape. Alongside the familiar list of links, assistants now compose a single answer and name a handful of businesses. More than half of travellers have already used AI to plan or book a trip, and most who use it act on what it tells them. This is no longer an emerging trend. It is how a growing share of your future visitors decide.

This rewards clarity over size. Assistants recommend the businesses they can understand and trust, which is not always the biggest name. It also carries a risk: a smaller operator can be left out simply because its information is thin or inconsistent. GEO is how you make sure your business is one an assistant can confidently put forward.

Worth naming honestly: assistants sometimes lean on the same well known names, which can crowd out everyone else. Good GEO is precisely how a lesser known but excellent business earns its place in the answer.

02 How AI search actually works

Two pathways

AI search reaches your visitor in two ways. The first is inside familiar search: Google now places an AI written summary, the AI Overview, above the normal results, drawing on the open web. The second is the assistant interface: ChatGPT, Gemini, Perplexity and Copilot, where the visitor asks a question in conversation and gets a direct answer, often with a few sources named.

How an assistant decides what to recommend

An assistant retrieves content it can read, favours pages that answer the question clearly, cross checks facts across several sources, and leans on the places it already trusts: reference sites, reviews and structured profiles. It quotes what is extractable, specific and consistent. The businesses it recommends are the ones it can understand without effort and trust without contradiction.

GEO, and how it relates to SEO

GEO is not a trick or a hack. It is making genuinely useful, well structured, consistent information easy for a machine to use. It builds on SEO rather than replacing it: the same foundations help, a clean structure, a fast site, good content. What shifts is the goal. You are no longer only trying to rank a link. You are trying to be the source an assistant quotes in its answer, which puts more weight on direct answers, structured data, and facts that agree across the web.

03 The six pillars of GEO

Six things determine whether an assistant can find, understand, trust and recommend your business. Each carries a short checklist you can act on.

Pillar one

Answer-first content

Assistants quote the page that answers the question, not the one that sells hardest.

What good looks like. Your key pages open with a direct answer, use headings phrased as the questions visitors ask, and keep each section self contained.

- Your top pages answer the visitor's question in the first two sentences.
- Headings are phrased as real questions, for example how do I get there, is it suitable for families.
- Each section makes sense on its own, lifted out of the page.
- Specifics are present: times, prices, distances, seasons, named places.

Pillar two

Structured data and schema

Schema tells a machine exactly what a fact is, an event, a price, a place, removing ambiguity about what to quote.

What good looks like. Valid schema on your key pages, matched exactly to the visible content, never describing something the page does not show.

- Your key page types carry the right schema, for your venue, events and offers.
- The schema matches what a visitor actually sees on the page.
- You validate it with a free tool such as Google's Rich Results Test.

Pillar three

A consistent entity

Assistants trust facts that agree with each other across the web, and drop or misdescribe businesses whose facts conflict.

What good looks like. Your name, address, contact and core facts are identical and correct everywhere: your site, Google Business Profile, the major platforms, and where relevant Wikidata.

- Name, address, phone and hours are identical across your site and all listings.
- Your Google Business Profile is claimed, complete and current.
- Major platform profiles, such as Tripadvisor and the OTAs, are accurate.
- For notable businesses, a correct Wikidata entry exists.

Pillar four

Authority and citations

Assistants lean on third party signals, reviews, mentions and best of lists, to decide who to trust.

What good looks like. You earn genuine reviews, accurate listings, and mentions in the round ups and guides that answer the visitor's question.

-  You actively gather genuine reviews and respond to them.
-  You appear, accurately, in relevant best of and category guides.
-  Your listings on trusted third party sites are complete.

Pillar five

Technical access

A page an assistant cannot read cannot be recommended, however good it is.

What good looks like. The main AI crawlers can reach your site by design, and your pages load quickly and work on a phone.

-  Your robots.txt allows the main AI crawlers: GPTBot, Google-Extended, ClaudeBot and PerplexityBot.
-  Your site loads quickly and works well on mobile.
-  Your important content is in text, not locked inside images or PDFs.

Pillar six

Measurement

Visibility shifts as models update, so you need to watch it, not assume it.

What good looks like. You check how you appear in the main assistants for your priority questions, and act on what you find.

-  You have a set of priority questions a visitor would ask.
-  You run them in the main assistants on a regular schedule.
-  You record where you appear and what is said, and act on the gaps.

A practical point on schema. Google retired FAQ rich results in 2026, and assistants do not give FAQ markup any special treatment. What matters is answering real questions in clear, visible content. Use schema to describe what is genuinely on the page, never as a visibility trick.

04 Your first ninety days

You do not need to do everything at once. This sequence puts the highest return work first.

Phase one THIS MONTH, THE FOUNDATIONS

- Fix your facts everywhere: make name, address, hours and contact identical and correct across your site and every listing.
- Claim and complete your Google Business Profile.
- Rewrite your three most important pages to answer the visitor's main question first.
- Check your robots.txt allows the main AI crawlers.

Phase two NEXT QUARTER, BUILD

- Add valid schema to your key page types, matched to the visible content.
- Extend the answer first rewrite across your priority pages.
- Start gathering genuine reviews systematically, and reply to them.
- Fix any major mobile or page speed problems.

Phase three ONGOING, MEASURE AND REFINE

- Set your priority questions and check them in the assistants each month.
- Keep your facts consistent as things change.
- For notable businesses, create or correct your Wikidata entry.
- Review what is working each quarter and adjust.

05 Checklists by business type

The pillars apply to everyone. These are the specifics that matter most for each kind of business.

Attractions and experiences

- 📌 Opening times, prices and how to book, clearly on the page and in text.
- 📌 The common questions answered directly: is it suitable for families, for accessibility, in bad weather.
- 📌 How to get there, with travel times from the main hubs.
- 📌 Event and ticket schema where relevant.

Accommodation

- 📌 Location, room types, prices and what is included, clearly stated.
- 📌 Honest answers to the usual questions: parking, breakfast, check in times, accessibility.
- 📌 Consistent details across your site, Google and the OTAs.
- 📌 Genuine reviews gathered and answered.

Food and drink

- 📌 Opening hours, the kind of food, price range and booking, in text and not only in an image or PDF menu.
- 📌 Dietary options answered plainly.
- 📌 A complete Google Business Profile with current hours and recent photos.

Tours and activity operators

- 📌 What is included, the duration, the meeting point, the price and how to book.
- 📌 Suitability and accessibility answered directly.
- 📌 Availability and seasonality stated clearly.

06 Quick wins this week

- 📌 Make your opening hours identical on your site and on Google.
- 📌 Rewrite the first paragraph of your most visited page to answer its main question.
- 📌 Claim your Google Business Profile if you have not already.
- 📌 Run three questions a visitor would ask in ChatGPT, and see whether you appear.

07 Mistakes to avoid, and the line not to cross

- 📌 Marketing copy where an answer should be. Lead with the useful thing.
- 📌 Facts that disagree across the web. Fix the contradictions first.
- 📌 Important information locked in images or PDFs. Put it in text.
- 📌 Treating FAQ schema as a trick. Answer real questions in visible content.

THE LINE NOT TO CROSS

Do not try to game the systems. Hidden text, fake reviews, and content written to deceive an assistant are against platform rules, easy to detect, and damaging when found. GEO is about making genuinely good information easy to use, not about manipulation. The businesses that win are the clear and trustworthy ones, and that is by design.

08 Measuring whether it is working

Pick a small set of questions a visitor would ask about your business, and run the same set across ChatGPT, Gemini and Perplexity once a month. Record where you appear and what gets cited, and watch the trend rather than any single reading. In your website analytics, keep an eye on referral traffic coming from the assistants.

A simple sheet is enough to start. Several paid tools track this in more depth if you want it later, but the habit matters more than the tool.

09 Glossary

GEO, Generative Engine Optimisation. Structuring your content and presence so AI assistants can understand, trust and recommend your business.

LLM, Large Language Model. The technology behind assistants like ChatGPT, Gemini and Claude.

AI Overview. The AI written summary that appears above Google's usual results.

Assistant interface. A tool such as ChatGPT, Gemini or Perplexity, where the visitor asks in conversation and gets a direct answer.

Schema, or structured data. Code that tells a machine what a piece of content is, for example an event, a price or a place.

Entity. How the web identifies your business as a distinct thing, tied to a consistent set of facts.

Crawler. The automated reader a search or AI system uses to read your website.

Citation. When an assistant names or links your business as a source in its answer.

10 Where to get help

The [destination] team is here to support you. [Contact name and email]. You will also find the wider set of resources, and the destination's own guidance, in the partner area. If you work with a web or content agency, share this guide with them as the standard to build to.

Prepared with the Digital Tourism Think Tank as part of the [destination] AI Discoverability programme. Adapt the bracketed fields before sharing. Statistics: Phocuswright and TakeUp, 2026.